

Pope’s empathy captivated world



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

WITH THE PEOPLE

Francis waves to pilgrims in San Cristobal de las Casas, Mexico, in 2016. On Easter two days ago, the pontiff blessed thousands in St. Peter’s Square, riding on the popemobile and drawing cheers two weeks after his hospital stay for double pneumonia.

POPE FRANCIS, 1936 - 2025

Humble Jesuit from Latin America shook up the scandal-ridden church

BY HENRY CHU

Pope Francis, the first pontiff from Latin America, whose warm, humble, no-nonsense manner galvanized the Roman Catholic Church and drew widespread admiration from outsiders almost from the moment of his surprise election to the throne of St. Peter in 2013, has died.

The church’s 266th leader, Francis died Monday morning, the Vatican announced. He was 88.

Francis’ death came the morning after he made a high-profile appearance, giving the traditional Easter blessing from the balcony of St. Peter’s Basilica in the Vatican following a brief meeting with Vice President JD Vance.

The Vatican said Francis died of a cerebral stroke that put him into a coma and led to heart failure. Francis was weeks removed from a lengthy hospital stay to treat pneumonia and a complex lung infection.

“Dearest brothers and sisters, with deep sorrow I must announce the death of our Holy Father Francis,” Cardinal Kevin Farrell’s statement released by the Vatican read. “At 7:35 this morning, the Bishop of Rome, Francis, returned to the house of the Father. His entire life was dedicated to the service of the Lord and of His Church.”

Francis was beloved by many for his public displays of compassion, commitment to social justice and willingness to shake up the scandal-ridden Vatican. He largely hewed to the church’s [See Pope, A4]

‘A man of peace’ is mourned in SoCal

BY NATHAN SOLIS, JENNY JARVIE AND ANTHONY SOLORZANO

Catholics across California mourned the death of Pope Francis on Monday, paying tribute to his modernization of the Roman Catholic Church and steadfast commitment to the poor and marginalized.

Francis, the first pontiff from Latin America, never visited California. But he forged a close bond with the more than 5 million Catholics who live in Los Angeles, largely because he nudged the church to a more tolerant position on social issues — by urging compassion for immigrants, arguing for tolerance of gay people and advocating for action on climate change.

“I have to say what I’m feeling today is very personal,” the archbishop of Los Angeles, José H. Gomez, told a crowd of nearly 2,000 mourners and tourists who poured into a noon Mass at the Cathedral of Our Lady of the Angels in downtown Los Angeles. “I’m going to miss him — big time.”

Francis, the Catholic Church’s 266th leader, made history when he became the first Latin American pontiff in 2013.

Born in 1936 in Argentina to Italian immigrants, he was also the first pope to take his papal name from St. Francis of Assisi, a saint who dedicated his life to serving the poor.

Gomez said Francis was like a wise father, a big brother. The fact that he was from a Latin American country — and the first pope to speak Spanish — meant a lot to people in that part of the world, including immigrants in L.A.

“It was very special to us,” Gomez, who was born in Monterrey, Mexico, said after [See Catholics, A5]

The reputed boss of a fearsome gang

Prosecutors say one name has been a constant in the Rollin’ 60s: ‘Big U’

BY BRITTNY MEJIA AND LIBOR JANY

Even in the cutthroat world of Los Angeles street gangs, the saying associated with one Crips faction stands out as cold-blooded: “You ain’t a Rollin’ 60 ‘til you kill a 60.”

The Rollin’ 60s Neighborhood Crips — which is said to be named for West 60th Street, which rolled through its territory in South Los Angeles — have a reputation for violence, sometimes even against fellow members. But that hasn’t stopped them from growing into one of the largest and most notorious

street gangs in the city, if not the country.

The gang’s foot soldiers and shot callers have been many over the years, but one name has seemingly remained constant: Eugene “Big U” Henley.

Henley came up around the time that Hollywood turned gang life in the City of

Angels into the stuff of legends. By the time the Rollin’ 60s were name-dropped in the 1991 classic “Boyz n the Hood,” he had already risen through the ranks.

Much has changed since then. Gang-related shootings have plummeted from the historic highs a genera- [See Henley, A14]

Bass strikes hopeful tone in State of City speech despite crises

BY JULIA WICK, DAVID ZAHNISER AND NOAH GOLDBERG

With Los Angeles battered by multiple crises, Mayor Karen Bass vowed Monday in her State of the City address to rebuild at a record clip in the wake of the Palisades fire while also overcoming dire financial woes.

Bass, appearing at City Hall before an audience of about 250, struck a hopeful tone, even as she acknowledged that the city is under stress on a variety of fronts: declining film and television production, a looming trade war and a housing market that is unaffordable for many.

Faced with a nearly \$1-billion budget shortfall, Bass [See Bass, A11]

Even on Earth Day, the U.S. is divided

GOP is rolling back environment rules that date to Nixon era as Democrats push climate protections.

BY HAYLEY SMITH

This year marks the 55th anniversary of Earth Day, but rather than enjoying its golden years, the planet is facing a new kind of peril. In recent weeks, the Republican Party — the same party that oversaw the creation of



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

A FEMALE bald eagle sits in her nest to tend to her two eaglets in northern Orange County in 2024.

the eco-conscious holiday back in 1970 — has delivered considerable blows to the environment, including taking steps to undo critical Nixon-era policies that protect the nation’s air, water, natural lands and threatened species.

President Nixon presided over the first Earth Day, founded in large part as a reaction to a devastating oil spill off the coast of California.

The holiday ushered in a decade of environmental activism and legislation under his conservative leadership. [See Earth Day, A8]

Trump backs beleaguered Hegseth

White House downplays reports of Defense secretary sharing data via second Signal chat. **WORLD, A3**

State’s solar credits targeted

Lawmaker aims to shrink benefits for those who install eco-friendly systems. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Sunny.
L.A. Basin: 70/55. **B6**

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